

The Persistence of Superstition: How Culture and Cognition Keep Old Beliefs Alive

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Abstract

The purpose of this research is to understand how superstitions continue to influence human behavior in modern society, examining the psychological behavior that drives people to believe in them. Superstitions have existed across cultures for centuries, often rooted in fear, religion, or folklore. While many originate from historical events or ancient beliefs, they have evolved into everyday habits that still guide behavior and decision-making. A qualitative and historical analysis was conducted by examining cultural folklore and psychological interpretations through sources such as Ana Sandoiu's Medical News Today article on the psychological effects of superstitions and Natalie Wolchover's Live Science article on the historical origins of common superstitions. These sources, including others, were used to trace recurring patterns and reveal how superstitions continue to shape behavior across time and cultures. This research concludes that superstitions persist not because people believe in them literally, but because they offer emotional relief, familiarity, and a sense of control in uncertain situations. Future research should examine how superstitions are being reshaped in the digital age, where new forms of belief and ritual may be spreading in ways that mirror traditional superstitions.

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When People sneeze, it is usually met with a fast response of the word “Bless you.” Almost everyone automatically replies without giving it much thought. But have you ever stopped to wonder why we even say it in the first place? Well, this common phrase originated in an ancient superstition rooted in the belief that sneezing might release your soul or invite evil spirits. Even today, although we don’t actually worry about evil spirits or losing our souls, we still reflexively say, “Bless you.” Superstitions like this have been embedded deeply into our lives for centuries, influencing human behavior across different cultures worldwide. At first glance, they may be completely irrational, but superstitions provide us with an odd sense of control in an otherwise unpredictable world. Even today, in our era of scientific advancements and logical reasoning, many people still instinctively avoid walking under ladders or knocking on wood to avoid bad luck.

By examining the roots of these beliefs and understanding their psychological impact, we can better grasp why they persist and how significantly they shape our lives. Throughout this paper, we will first explore the psychology behind why superstitions exist and why our minds are inclined toward believing them. Next, we will delve into their historical and cultural origins, uncovering the surprising reasons behind some familiar rituals. Lastly, we will investigate how these superstitions continue to influence our modern behaviors and decisions in everyday life.

Psychology

Our brains are wired to seek out patterns, even when there might not be any logical connection (Vyse 5). This behavior explains why we often associate unrelated events with one another, a key factor behind many superstitions. Stuart Vyse, a psychologist who studied superstitious beliefs, suggests humans have evolved to seek patterns as a survival mechanism, helping us predict and control our surroundings (Vyse 5). It becomes a problem when we start believing in connections that don't logically exist, like thinking wearing a certain shirt will always help us pass exams. Personally, I realize I often find myself connecting good or bad luck to completely unrelated actions or items, which highlights just how ingrained pattern-seeking is in our everyday life.

This habit of finding patterns where none exist leads to a cognitive bias called magical thinking (Risen 185). Magical thinking happens when people believe their thoughts or actions directly influence unrelated outcomes in the world. Jane Risen, a psychologist whose work explores irrational beliefs, describes this as “thought-action fusion,” a situation where we mistakenly believe our thoughts can cause real-world effects, even though there's no rational basis for such beliefs (Risen 185). For example, thinking negatively about an event might lead someone to genuinely fear that their negative thoughts could cause harm, leading them to adopt rituals to prevent these outcomes. Reflecting on this, I've noticed myself performing small rituals, like knocking on wood, when I don't want to jinx myself, reinforcing how subtle and common these biases can be.

Furthermore, Garcia-Montes and his colleagues, experts in psychological disorders and superstition, argue that magical thinking isn't just an occasional slip but deeply tied to our emotional states (Garcia-Montes 229). When people experience anxiety or uncertainty, they often

use superstition as a coping mechanism, believing that certain actions or rituals can help manage or even alter stressful situations (Garcia-Montes 229). This type of thinking provides emotional comfort by giving a sense of control, even if that control is merely an illusion. Thinking about this, I recognize that when stressed, engaging in minor superstitious behaviors gives me a brief sense of relief, which shows just how emotionally powerful these beliefs can be.

Another important psychological factor behind superstition is the illusion of control. Ellen Langer, a renowned psychologist known for her research on decision-making, defines the illusion of control as the tendency for people to overestimate their ability to control events, particularly when facing uncertainty (Langer 312). This illusion often leads individuals to adopt rituals or charms, like carrying lucky items or performing specific actions before important events, because they mistakenly believe these rituals can influence outcomes positively.

For example, athletes commonly engage in superstitious rituals before games, believing these actions can directly affect their performance. This phenomenon occurs because rituals help reduce anxiety by providing a sense of predictability and security, even though there is no logical connection between the rituals and actual outcomes. Reflecting on my experiences, I notice how engaging in my research presentation rituals gives me a feeling of being better prepared, despite logically knowing that these actions have no real effect on the outcome.

Suzanne Thompson, another psychologist who studied illusions of control, adds that these beliefs become stronger when the situation feels personal and familiar or when we focus on successes (Thompson 188). She explains that people often use a mental shortcut called a “control heuristic” where, if we intended a result and our action is followed by that result, we assume we caused it (Thompson 189). This kind of thinking helps explain why rituals feel powerful, because we link our intention with the outcome. When I think about it, I’ve definitely felt like I had

“better luck” on days when I followed a certain routine with my hobby of playing the drums, even though I knew it was probably just a coincidence.

Another reason superstitions continue is because of conditioning (Vyse 35). Which is when someone repeats a behavior because it seems to lead to a good outcome. In one study, pigeons started doing odd repeated actions like spinning in circles because they believed those actions were making food appear, even though the food came randomly (Vyse 35). Humans are similar. We might keep doing something that seemed to work once, like wearing a lucky shirt on test day, and ignore the times it didn't help. Over time, the behavior becomes a ritual, even if it doesn't actually change anything.

Partial reinforcement, where rewards come occasionally but not always, is especially strong in keeping these habits going. It tricks the brain into thinking the action is working, so we keep doing it just in case (Vyse 36). This makes superstitious behaviors hard to stop. Even when people know the outcome is random, the emotional memory of something “working once” keeps them stuck in the cycle. I can relate to this when I think about the times I pretended not to care, looking at my phone in hopes that my YouTube video would finally load due to internet difficulties. I've held onto little routines like this because I felt it helped once, even if it probably didn't.

Superstitious behaviors also stick because they provide emotional relief. When someone is anxious or afraid of an uncertain outcome, doing a ritual, even a small one, can make them feel safer (Garcia-Montes 231). It's not the action that changes anything; it's the feeling it creates. Personally, I've noticed I turn to small habits when I feel anxious, like double-checking things or closing my eyes. It doesn't always make sense, but it makes me feel better, and that feeling can be hard to let go of.

Fear, hope, and grief play a major role in keeping superstitions alive. When people are afraid of something they can't control, like losing a job, getting sick, or failing a test, they are more likely to rely on rituals or symbols to help manage that fear. These behaviors don't fix the problem, but they give emotional comfort in the moment (Garcia-Montes 230). Superstitions work like a temporary emotional shield. They make the world feel a little less random, even if it's just in our minds.

People in grief or under emotional stress often turn to rituals, even if they've never believed in them before. This is especially true when facing loss or uncertainty. The feeling of doing something gives them a sense of action and comfort. Even when someone knows a ritual doesn't logically work, the emotional payoff makes it feel worth doing (Risen 186). I've seen this in myself and others when they put on a specific necklace, pray extra, or wear something meaningful just to feel grounded. Even though I know these things don't guarantee an outcome, they help settle those emotions.

Mood can also influence how likely someone is to rely on superstition. People in a low or anxious mood tend to seek out more rituals or superstitious behaviors because those habits create a calming structure (Thompson 190). We feel that we need more control when we start to feel less of it emotionally. Looking back, some of my most superstitious habits came from moments when I felt the most overwhelmed or uncertain.

History

Many modern superstitions can be traced back to ancient religious and magical practices. Early societies often used rituals to try to influence forces they didn't understand, like the weather, illness, or death. These rituals were tied to beliefs about gods, spirits, or fate. Over time,

these beliefs didn't completely disappear. Instead, they were simplified into the everyday habits and sayings we now call superstitions (Frazer 52).

One everyday example that shows how deeply superstition is woven into our behavior is the phrase "bless you" after someone sneezes. We say it almost automatically, but few people stop to think about where this habit comes from. Historically, sneezing was viewed as dangerous, especially during times of disease. During the Plague of Justinian in the 6th century and later during the Black Death in the 14th century, sneezing was seen as an early sign of sickness, which was in most fatal. In response, Pope Gregory I suggested people say "God bless you" as a short prayer, hoping it would shield the sneezer from illness or death (Wolchover). At the same time, some believed sneezing could cause the soul to momentarily escape the body, making the person vulnerable to evil spirits. Saying "bless you" was thought to shield the spirit from danger. While we no longer associate sneezing with a deadly illness or spiritual danger, the phrase has lived on. It's become a social reflex, passed down through generations. This shows how rituals rooted in fear or religious belief can gradually turn into everyday manners, losing their original meaning but keeping their place in culture.

Folklore has helped keep these kinds of beliefs alive. Through stories, warnings, and old sayings, people continue to pass down superstitions that once held deep emotional or cultural importance. These stories are often more than entertainment—they carry lessons and reflect the values of the community. They might warn about bad luck, offer protection, or teach respect for unseen forces. As the American folklorist Louise Pound noted, folklore often contains hidden meanings related to survival, control, and social order (Pound 5). These meanings may not be obvious to the person hearing them today, but they help explain why people still follow certain customs, even when they seem irrational. Saying "bless you," carrying a lucky charm, or

avoiding a black cat aren't just random acts, they reflect how people once tried to make sense of the unpredictable world around them.

Some of these traditions also emerged from early attempts to explain natural phenomena before science offered better answers. Take the example of breaking a mirror. In ancient times, reflections were believed to hold a piece of the human soul. Mirrors were considered magical or sacred objects. Damaging a reflection, then, could mean damaging the soul itself. Over time, this belief evolved into the superstition that breaking a mirror would bring seven years of bad luck (Wolchover). Today, most people don't believe in soul-mirrors, but the fear of breaking one still lingers. This superstition reveals something deeper: the human need to make sense of misfortune and the desire to control outcomes, even when there's no rational connection.

Looking at these examples together, it becomes clear that superstitions are not just silly or outdated beliefs. They arise from a fundamental human need to feel safe, to understand the unknown, and to preserve traditions that have meaning, whether spiritual, cultural, or emotional. I've experienced this myself. Growing up, I heard warnings like "don't open an umbrella indoors" or "don't sweep over someone's feet." At the time, they felt serious, even sacred. Now, they might seem funny or odd, but they were always tied to bigger ideas about protection, respect, or consequences. In that way, superstitions are like invisible threads that connect the past to the present. They shape how we act, often without us even realizing it. They travel by moving from one generation to the next and from one society to another. One reason this happens is because traditions are built into everyday habits and stories. People repeat what they see and hear as they grow up. Even if the original meaning is lost, the behavior stays. As Simon Bronner, who is also an American folklorist and ethnologist, puts it, tradition works because people "follow the practice without necessarily understanding the reason behind it" (Bronner, 3).

Storytelling is a powerful tool in this process. Folklore often includes stories about bad luck, omens, or rituals that teach people how to behave or what to avoid. These stories act like warnings passed down over time. According to Pound, this helps people “organize experience” and gives them a sense of cultural identity (Pound, 6). Whether it's about avoiding black cats or wearing a lucky charm, the message becomes part of how a group explains the world to itself.

Sometimes, superstitions spread because they're emotionally satisfying. Roorda describes how athletes, especially in American sports like baseball and football, adopt superstitions that start small, like wearing a specific pair of socks, and eventually turn into full routines (Roorda 61). Once a behavior feels lucky, it's easy to copy. Other players might imitate it, and over time, it spreads through teams or entire fan cultures. This isn't just about luck; it's about community and control.

Migration also plays a role. When people move, they bring their traditions with them. Superstitions can mix with local beliefs and evolve into something new. For example, traditions from Europe, Africa, and Indigenous tribes have all blended into American culture. These blended superstitions can take on new meanings while still giving people a sense of identity and heritage.

Thinking about this makes me realize how much of what I believe or avoid came from others, parents, friends, even things I saw on TV. Sometimes I don't know why I do something; I just know I've seen it done. That's how traditions keep moving, whether we notice or not.

While some superstitions feel universal, many are specific to individual cultures. These beliefs often reflect what a society values or fears most. For example, in some East Asian cultures, the number four is avoided because its pronunciation sounds like the word for death. Elevators in countries like China or Japan sometimes skip the fourth floor entirely. In contrast,

the number thirteen is seen as unlucky in many Western countries, especially in the United States, where buildings often don't have a 13th floor (Park, 116).

Superstitions in American sports offer another example. Roorda describes how rituals like pre-game prayers, wearing certain colors, or following specific routines are common in football and baseball. These habits reflect more than just fear of bad luck, they connect to the culture of performance, discipline, and anxiety about losing (Roorda 64). Athletes and fans alike use them to feel more in control of the outcome, even though they know the actual result depends on skill.

Some beliefs are shaped by the way a community handles uncertainty. In cultures where events like natural disasters or illness are seen as unpredictable, people may rely more on charms, prayers, or taboos. Bronner points out that these rituals often serve not just a spiritual purpose, but a social one, reminding people of group identity and shared values (Bronner 9). A superstition might seem small, like knocking on wood, but it represents deeper cultural attitudes about safety, community, and respect.

Even within one country, different regions or ethnic groups may practice unique traditions. What's seen as normal in one area might be strange in another. This shows how deeply embedded superstitions are in cultural identity. Reflecting on this makes me think about how even casual habits in my family, like tossing salt over your shoulder or avoiding certain days to make big decisions, connect us to cultural stories that go beyond our generation.

Modern Influence

Even in today's modern world, filled with science, logic, and technology, superstitions still quietly shape how we go through the day. From knocking on wood to avoid bad luck to crossing fingers for good fortune, these small rituals are part of many people's routines, even if they don't fully believe in them. These habits often feel harmless, but they come from deep-

seated beliefs that were once taken very seriously. For example, knocking on wood dates back to ancient times when people believed spirits lived in trees. Knocking was thought to summon the spirits for protection or to avoid offending them (Wolchover). Today, most people don't associate the action with forest spirits, but the habit continues as a quick way to guard against misfortune. This shows how superstition can become automatic, passed down more through habit than belief. When I think about how naturally I do this without questioning it, I see how superstition sometimes becomes more about social or emotional comfort than actual belief.

Other small behaviors also linger from older belief systems. People still avoid walking under ladders, not because they're afraid of the structure collapsing, but because of a lingering sense that it "feels wrong." The superstition comes from the shape of the ladder forming a triangle, a symbol of the Holy Trinity. Walking through it was seen as breaking a sacred space (Wolchover). While this Christian symbolism isn't on most people's minds today, the idea of avoiding that space remains. These are the kinds of moments where belief hides in plain sight. We carry these behaviors with us, not always because we understand them, but because they've been quietly embedded into our culture and childhood. I catch myself avoiding walking under ladders too, even though I know the history, because something about it still gives me that odd gut feeling.

Lucky objects are also part of modern life. Athletes wear "lucky socks" or carry charms. Students might bring a certain pen to every test. These objects offer a sense of comfort and control, especially in situations that are unpredictable. Even though people might admit the item doesn't actually affect the outcome, they feel better using it. This mix of belief and habit is what keeps superstitions alive. As Park explains, superstition often blends psychological comfort with tradition, making it stick around long after its original meaning fades (Park, 117). I know that

I've relied on lucky items during times of stress, not because I think they're magic, but because they give me a moment to feel grounded. It's not about the object—it's about how I feel when I use it. That emotional reassurance is powerful.

Superstitions can also be found in sayings and small choices people make throughout the day. Some avoid the number 13 when choosing hotel rooms or plane seats. Others won't schedule important events on Friday the 13th. These actions reflect a quiet influence—people don't always call it superstition, but their behavior is shaped by it anyway. Bronner writes that traditions are often followed “without questioning their logic” because they become part of a person's rhythm of life (Bronner, 7). Once something becomes familiar, it sticks, even without strong belief behind it. That makes me think about how many of my own behaviors are just inherited rhythms. We think we're moving through life logically, but we still pause at certain numbers or days out of a subtle, learned hesitation. These invisible habits show how superstition quietly rides alongside our choices.

Reflecting on my own habits, I realize I still follow some of these without thinking. I've knocked on wood, crossed my fingers, and avoided things that “felt unlucky.” I know they don't change the outcome, but in the moment, they give me a little peace of mind. It's comforting to feel like I'm doing something, if it's small, to keep bad luck away. That's the quiet power of everyday superstitions: they don't ask us to fully believe, just to act out of habit, tradition, or hope. And maybe that's the part that matters most—not whether the ritual is true, but that it helps us feel like we have a little bit of control in a world that often feels random. Joining this conversation made me realize that superstition isn't about ignorance, it's about emotion, memory, and meaning woven into ordinary actions.

Superstitions aren't just part of individual habits—they show up in larger systems too. In places like medicine, sports, and even business, people continue to act on beliefs that have no scientific proof but still offer a feeling of security or structure. These settings are often high-pressure environments, where people face outcomes they can't fully control. That's where superstition steps in, giving a sense of order and preparation, even if it's imagined.

In sports, this is especially noticeable. Athletes are known for having detailed pre-game rituals: wearing the same jersey, following a routine playlist, stepping onto the field with a specific foot first. These habits might look silly from the outside, but to the athlete, they provide mental stability. Roorda explains that these rituals create a sense of personal control over unpredictable events, like winning or losing (Roorda, 63). Even fans buy into the ritual—some wear lucky shirts or sit in the same spot during every game. These practices don't guarantee a win, but they bond people together through shared belief. Thinking about this makes me realize how rituals create unity—not just between players, but between teams and their fans. That shared superstition becomes part of the culture.

In medicine, superstition appears in subtler ways. Some hospitals skip the 13th floor. Some doctors avoid surgeries on Friday the 13th, or patients reschedule major operations because of a bad feeling about a date. These decisions aren't based on scientific evidence, but they're respected because of patient comfort. In high-stakes fields like healthcare, the smallest emotional reassurance can make a difference. Park writes that even professionals sometimes follow superstitions because it “feels safer” (Park, 119). I find that fascinating—how people trained in logic and evidence can still turn to superstition in times of stress. It shows that even with knowledge, emotion still plays a huge role in decision-making.

Even in business or politics, superstition has a subtle presence. Companies avoid launching products on the 13th, hotels skip certain floor numbers, and some CEOs rely on rituals or objects for confidence during big pitches. These actions aren't just tradition, they reflect how deeply superstition is tied to risk. When success feels uncertain, people often look for anything that gives them confidence, even if it's symbolic. Personally, I think that makes superstition not just an individual act, but a collective language we use to handle stress. It makes the unpredictable feel manageable, and that's something nearly everyone craves.

Conclusion

Throughout this paper, I've explored the different ways superstition continues to shape our lives, from the psychology behind it, to its cultural and historical origins, to the small but noticeable ways it still shows up in everyday routines. What started as ancient attempts to understand and survive a confusing world has now become part of our habits and traditions. Even though we live in a time filled with science, technology, and logic, these beliefs haven't disappeared. Instead, they've found subtle ways to stay with us, quietly influencing our behavior, often without us even realizing it.

Superstitions last not because we fully believe in them, but because they give us something we can't always get from reason: comfort. They offer a sense of control when life feels uncertain, and they help us feel connected to something, whether it's our culture, our childhood, or even just a moment of hope. It's easier to laugh off a ritual than admit we're nervous or afraid, and so we hold onto these behaviors. I know I do. I've caught myself knocking on wood during conversations or avoiding things that feel "off," even though I know better. It doesn't make sense logically, but emotionally, it feels like insurance—just in case.

I've realized that these beliefs are a kind of emotional language. They let us respond to fear, luck, and hope in ways that words sometimes can't. They also connect us to others. When someone says "bless you," or jokes about Friday the 13th, we know exactly what they mean. It's like a shared understanding that goes beyond belief—it's cultural muscle memory. We might outgrow certain superstitions, but others stay with us, shaping how we think, act, and even make decisions.

At the end of the day, whether you cross your fingers, avoid stepping on cracks, or knock on wood to avoid disappointment, superstitions are part of the rhythm of life. They don't require us to believe with full certainty, they just ask us to follow, repeat, and maybe feel a little more at ease. So next time you instinctively say "Bless you" after someone sneezes, pause and ask yourself: do you really believe in superstitions, or have they just become second nature?

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Wolchover, Natalie. "The Surprising Origins of 9 Common Superstitions" *Live Science*, September 19, 2011. <https://www.livescience.com/33507-origins-of-superstitions.html>

Literature Review

Introduction

This literature review surveys five key academic sources that support the major arguments in my research paper, “How Superstitions Control Our Lives.” These sources were chosen based on how often they were referenced in key sections of my paper: the psychology behind superstitions, historical and cultural origins, and their continued impact on modern life. Together, these works offer insight into why superstitions persist despite scientific advancement, how they evolve across generations, and what needs they fulfill for individuals and communities.

Sources

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<http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/lonestar-ebooks/detail.action>

Stuart Vyse’s book is the backbone of the psychological section in my paper. Vyse, a psychologist who specializes in irrational belief systems, explains that superstitions arise from natural human tendencies, especially our pattern-seeking brains. He highlights how even pigeons, through Skinner’s classic experiment, developed rituals based on random reinforcement (Vyse, ch. 2). Humans do the same: we repeat behaviors that once seemed to bring good results, even if they had no real connection to the outcome. Vyse also discusses the power of partial reinforcement and how it reinforces superstitious routines. His work helped me explain why many people stick to rituals, like wearing lucky socks or knocking on wood, even when they know it’s not logical. Personally, reading Vyse gave me language to describe things I’d already noticed in myself, small rituals that make me feel less anxious, even though I know they’re not

magical. His writing is accessible and science-based, which makes it helpful for explaining concepts in a speech paper at a college level.

Risen, Jane L. “Believing what we do not believe: Acquiescence to superstitious beliefs and other powerful intuitions.” *Psychological Review*, 123(2), 182–207. 2016.

<https://doi.org/10.1037/rev0000017>

Risen’s article explores how people often “go along” with beliefs they don’t consciously accept. Her concept of “acquiescence” to superstition—acting on beliefs we don’t logically believe—was important for my section on magical thinking. She explains that people may think something like, “This probably won’t happen,” but still knock on wood “just in case” (Risen, 185). This helped support my argument that superstition doesn’t always rely on full belief; instead, it persists through small actions and emotional shortcuts. Risen’s work also added depth to my paper by showing how thought-action fusion connects fear to ritual behavior. It made me reflect on how even when I say, “I don’t really believe this,” I still sometimes do the thing—like avoiding cracks or saying “bless you.” Her psychological approach pairs well with Vyse’s and added nuance to how I presented cognitive bias in superstition.

Bronner, Simon J. “Explaining Traditions: Folk Behavior in Modern Culture.” *The University Press of Kentucky*, 2011. Project MUSE, <https://muse.jhu.edu/book/1977>.

Bronner’s book was essential for understanding how cultural superstitions are passed on. He explains that traditions persist not just because people believe in them, but because they become embedded in everyday behavior. This helped me write the section about how superstitions spread through storytelling, repetition, and family habits. I used his work to support the idea that many people follow superstitions “without questioning their logic,” especially when they are taught as norms from a young age (Bronner, 7). His work also helped frame how superstitions are social—

passed down like recipes or sayings, rather than just internal beliefs. It made me think about how I learned certain taboos growing up, not because I believed in them, but because they were shared with seriousness or humor. Bronner helped me make the argument that culture sustains superstition long after belief fades.

Wolchover, Natalie. "The Surprising Origins of 9 Common Superstitions" *Live Science*,

September 19, 2011. <https://www.livescience.com/33507-origins-of-superstitions.html>

Wolchover's article on Live Science served as a strong bridge between history and everyday life. Though it's more journalistic than academic, it's well-researched and frequently cited. She traces the backstories of common superstitions like knocking on wood, avoiding ladders, and breaking mirrors. I used this source in multiple parts of my paper to explain the hidden roots of everyday habits. For example, she explains how knocking on wood came from pagan beliefs in tree spirits, and how the triangle formed by a ladder symbolized the Holy Trinity (Wolchover). These examples helped me show how religion, fear, and symbolism still echo in modern routines. Her writing also helped ground the paper in accessible examples, which is especially important in a speech research assignment meant for a general audience.

Conclusion

Together, these sources helped shape the three main ideas of my research paper. The first point of why superstitions exist, the second point of where they come from, and the third point of how they still affect us today. Reading across these disciplines showed me how superstition is not just an irrational leftover, it's a meaningful behavior that responds to fear, tradition, and the human need for comfort. These sources gave me the tools to speak not just about what superstition is, but about what it means.